

Chapter 1 — Tracing Changes Through a Thousand Years

The one-line point: Before you learn medieval India, learn that **the words themselves have moved**. "Hindustan", "foreigner", even "Hindu" meant different things then. This chapter is about reading the past without smuggling the present into it.

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Medieval India
Sub-discipline	Historiography & Sources (methodological, like Class 6 Ch.1)
Period	Frames the whole span, 700–1750 CE
Prelims (GS Paper I)	<i>History of India</i> → sources, terminology, periodisation
Mains (GS Paper I)	Supplies framing and caveats; periodisation debate is directly quotable
Also feeds	Indian Society (jati, social mobility), Polity (the communal reading of history), Essay (how we name the past)
Weightage	★ ★ ★ — few direct questions, but it makes the rest of the book coherent
Overlaps with	Class 6 Ch.1 (same job, different millennium)

 **Not Modern History. This is Medieval India → Historiography.** The toolkit chapter again.

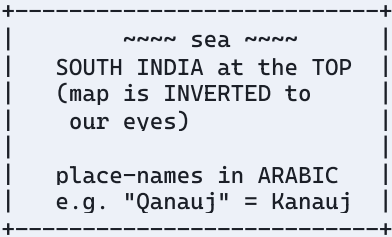
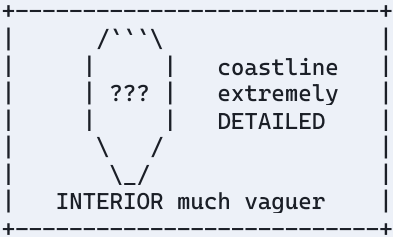
Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Explain** how the meaning of "**Hindustan**" changed between the 13th and 16th centuries, naming who used it and how.
- ☐ **State** what "foreigner" meant in medieval usage, and give the Hindi and Persian terms.
- ☐ **Describe** the manuscript problem — why no two copies of a text agree, and what that does to historians.
- ☐ **Name** the new technologies and new crops that arrived in this period.
- ☐ **Explain** the rise of the **Rajputs** and other new social groups, and what *Rajaputra* literally means.
- ☐ **Define** *jati* and *jati panchayat*, and explain how jati ranking varied by region.
- ☐ **Explain** why rulers made exaggerated territorial claims, and what a **pan-regional empire** was.
- ☐ **List** the regional languages Amir Khusrau named in 1318, and his point about Sanskrit.
- ☐ **Summarise** the major religious developments — temple Hinduism, bhakti, the arrival of Islam, Shia/Sunni, Sufism.
- ☐ **Critique** the "**Hindu–Muslim–British**" **periodisation**, say who introduced it, and explain why historians reject it. ★
- ☐ **Explain** why calling 700–1750 a single "medieval" period is itself problematic.

📖 Start Here: Two Maps of the Same Place

NCERT opens with two maps, and the comparison does real work:

MAP 1 – 1154 CE by AL-IDRISI, Arab geographer	MAP 2 – 1720s by a FRENCH cartographer (Guillaume de l'Isle, Atlas Nouveau)
	
Made for scholars of the Arab world	Made for EUROPEAN SAILORS and MERCHANTS
THE MAP TELLS YOU WHO MADE IT AND WHY. Map 2's coast is sharp and its interior fuzzy because the people who commissioned it arrived BY SEA and cared about ports, not about the Ganga valley.	

🔑 **The lesson:** a source is shaped by the purpose it was made for. Ask **"who made this, and what did they need it for?"** before asking **"is it accurate?"**

📊 You already do this instinctively with data: a metrics dashboard built by the billing team measures different things from one built by SRE. Neither is lying; each instruments what its authors cared about. **Al-Idrisi and de l'Isle instrumented different concerns.**

1 Words That Moved — The Core of This Chapter

📖 "HINDUSTAN" ★★ ★

This is the single most-tested idea in the chapter.

Who / When	What they meant by it
Minhaj-i Siraj , 13th century (chronicler)	A political term: the lands of Punjab, Haryana, and between the Ganga and Yamuna — i.e. the areas within the Delhi Sultanate's control. ★ It never included South India
Babur , early 16th century	A geographical and cultural term: the geography, fauna and culture of the inhabitants of the subcontinent
Amir Khusrau , 14th century	Used "Hind" in a broadly similar cultural sense
Today	"India" — the modern nation-state , with political and national meaning

★ **The exam point:** the idea of India as a geographical and cultural entity **did exist**, but **"Hindustan" did not carry the political-national meaning we now attach to it**. Reading modern nationhood back into a 13th-century word is precisely the error the chapter warns against.

Then

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2

Continuity with Class 6

Pa



A CENTURY LATER (14th)

A horizontal number line with tick marks at 0, $\frac{1}{2}$, and 1. The region between 0 and 1 is shaded light blue. The label v is placed below the tick mark at $\frac{1}{2}$.

records, **registers of accounts and taxes.**

archives.

There was **no printing press**. Scribes copied by hand — and **introduced small changes**, a word here, a sentence there.



After centuries, manuscripts of the SAME TEXT become SUBSTANTIALLY DIFFERENT from one another.

And we RARELY have the author's original -- we are almost entirely dependent on later scribal copies.

=> Historians must read SEVERAL manuscript versions and GUESS what the author originally wrote.



This is an unversioned fork chain with silent mutation and no origin commit. You have a dozen divergent copies, no upstream, and no diff against the original. The historian's job is essentially **reconstructing the ancestor from the descendants** — which is exactly what textual criticism does, and it is remarkably similar to inferring a common ancestor in phylogenetics.

The complication on top: authors themselves **revised** their work. The 14th-century chronicler **Ziyauddin Barani** wrote a chronicle and then **another version two years later** — the two differ, and historians didn't know about the second for a long time because it lay unnoticed in large library collections.



Prelims-relevant: Barani is the standard example of an author with two divergent versions. Also note **miniature paintings** — small illustrations (the one shown is 10.5 cm × 7.1 cm) used to illustrate manuscripts, so beautiful that **later collectors tore manuscripts apart to sell the miniatures alone**. That's a nice, quotable fact about how art markets destroy context.

3 New Social and Political Groups

The period 700–1750 is hard to summarise precisely because **so much changed at once**.

⚙️ New technologies and crops ★★

New technologies	New crops
The Persian wheel (irrigation)	Potatoes
The spinning wheel (weaving)	Corn (maize)
Firearms in combat	Chillies
	Tea
	Coffee



Prelims trap: potatoes, corn, chillies, tea and coffee are **not indigenous** — they arrive in this period. Chillies and potatoes especially surprise people, since they feel utterly Indian today. (Chillies and corn come from the Americas via the Columbian Exchange; the point that "Indian food" is historically layered is good Essay material.)



NCERT's framing is worth keeping: these innovations **came along with people, who brought other ideas with them as well**. Technology never travels alone.

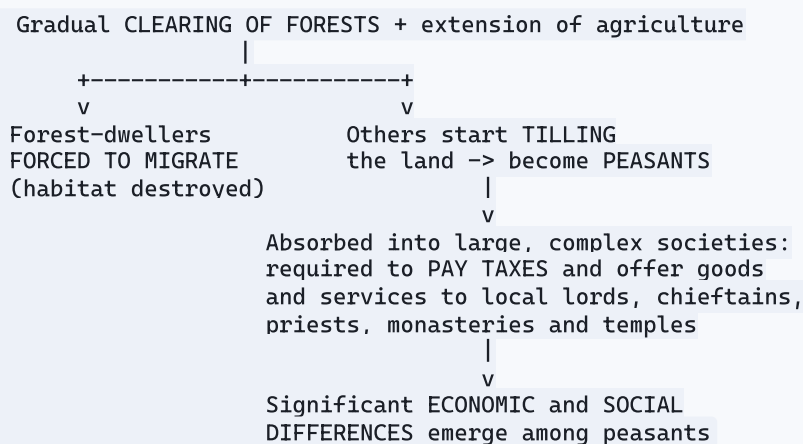
🐎 The Rajputs and other risers ★★

This was a period of **great mobility** — people travelled long distances in search of opportunity, and the subcontinent held wealth enough for fortunes to be made.

Group	Detail
RAJPUTS ★★	From " <i>Rajaputra</i> " = <i>son of a ruler</i> . Between the 8th and 14th centuries the term broadened to a group of warriors claiming Kshatriya status — including not just rulers and chieftains but soldiers and commanders serving in armies across the subcontinent. Their poets and bards attributed to them a chivalric code : extreme valour and a great sense of loyalty
Marathas, Sikhs, Jats, Ahoms	Also used the opportunities of the age to become politically important
Kayasthas ★	A caste of scribes and secretaries — rose through literacy and administration, not arms

🔴 **The pattern:** in a period of constant state formation, **military skill and administrative literacy were both routes upward**. Being *born* a Kshatriya mattered less than being *accepted* as one — a point Ch.2 makes explicit with the *hiranya-garbha* ritual.

🌳 Forest clearing and the making of peasants



Some peasants kept cattle; some combined **artisanal work with agriculture in the lean season**.

👁️ Jati ★★

As society became more differentiated, people were grouped into **jatis** (sub-castes), ranked by **birth and occupation**.

Key facts about jati
★ Ranks were not fixed — the status of the same jati could vary from area to area
Jatis framed their own rules and regulations to manage members' conduct
These were enforced by an assembly of elders — in some areas the jati panchayat ★
But jatis were also required to follow the rules of their villages
A village was governed by a chieftain; jatis were one small unit of a state

🔗 **Cross-link:** Class 6 Ch.4 gave you **varna** (four categories, from the Purusha Sukta). **Here you get jati** — the thousands of birth-based groups that are the actual lived structure of caste. **Varna ≠ jati**, and this chapter is where jati properly enters the story. Essential for GS1 Indian Society.

4 Region and Empire

By 700, many regions already had **distinct geographical dimensions, their own language and cultural characteristics**.

👤 Amir Khusrau on language, 1318 ★★

The poet listed a **different language in every region**:

Language	Region
Sindhi	Sind
Lahori	Lahore region
Kashmiri	Kashmir
Dvarsamudri	Southern Karnataka
Telangani	Andhra Pradesh
Gujari	Gujarat
Ma'bari	Tamil Nadu
Gauri	Bengal
Awadhi	Eastern Uttar Pradesh
Hindawi	The area around Delhi

★ **And his contrast:** unlike these, **Sanskrit did not belong to any region**. It was an old language, and "*common people do not know it, only the Brahmanas do.*"

🎯 **That observation is gold for Mains.** It captures in one line the difference between a **regional vernacular** (spoken, local, alive) and a **classical prestige language** (unregional, learned, restricted). It is exactly why the Bhakti and Sufi saints of Ch.6 chose the vernacular — and it echoes Class 6 Ch.6, where the Buddha chose Prakrit over Sanskrit for the same reason. **Same strategic choice, 1,800 years apart.**

👑 Pan-regional empires and exaggerated claims

Rulers made sweeping claims. A **Chola prashasti** describes its king as ruler of an empire stretching from **Gauda (Bengal)** in the east to **Gajjana (Ghazni, Afghanistan)** in the west, including all of **Dravida (south India)**.

Historians regard these as exaggerated. The interesting question NCERT poses is *why rulers kept making them* — the claim itself was a political act, asserting a status they aspired to.

Pan-regional empires — spanning diverse regions — were built by the **Cholas, Khaljis, Tughluqs and Mughals**. ★ **Not all were equally stable or successful.**

📖 **Note the source detail:** the map of Delhi Sultanate provinces under **Muhammad Tughluq** comes from an **Egyptian** source — the *Masalik al-absar fi mamalik al-amsar* of **Shihabuddin al-Umari**. A foreign observer documenting Indian administration — the Chapter 1 lesson of Class 6 recurring.

When the Mughal Empire declined in the 18th century, regional states re-emerged (Ch.8) — but they carried the **legacies** of the empires that had ruled them, visible in governance, economic management, elite cultures and language.

🔑 **NCERT's formulation, worth memorising:** "These regions felt the impact of larger pan-regional forces of integration without ever quite losing their distinctiveness." That sentence is the thesis of **Chapter 7** and a ready-made Mains opening.

5 Old and New Religions

🕉️ Changes within Hinduism

Development
Worship of new deities
Construction of temples by royalty ★
Growing importance of Brahmanas as a dominant group
Their position consolidated by the support of patrons — new rulers searching for prestige

🔑 **The mechanism to notice:** rulers needed legitimacy; Brahmanas could confer it; rulers gave land and temples; Brahmanas grew powerful. **A mutually reinforcing bargain** — precisely the same bargain you saw between kings and priests in Class 6 Ch.5 (the Ashvamedha).

A **patron** = a wealthy individual who supports another person — an artiste, a craftsman, a learned man, or a noble.

🙏 Bhakti emerges

One of the major developments of this period: the idea of **bhakti** — a loving, personal deity that devotees could reach **WITHOUT** the aid of priests or elaborate rituals. (Full treatment in Ch.6.)

🕌 The arrival of Islam

Fact	Detail
How	Merchants and migrants first brought Islam to India in the seventh century ★
Belief	Muslims regard the Quran as their holy book and accept the sovereignty of the one God, Allah , whose love, mercy and bounty embrace all who believe in Him — ★ without regard to social background
Patronage	Many rulers were patrons of Islam and of learned theologians and jurists
Diversity ★	Like Hinduism, Islam was interpreted in a variety of ways by its followers

The main division:

SHIA	SUNNI
Held that the Prophet Muhammad's son-in-law, Ali , was the legitimate leader of the Muslim community	Accepted the authority of the early leaders (Khalifas) of the community and the succeeding Khalifas

Also important: other differences of theology and law, and **mystic traditions — the Sufis** (Ch.6).

🌀 **Note the emphasis NCERT chooses:** that Islam's appeal included acceptance **without regard to social background**, and that both Hinduism and Islam were internally **diverse**. Both points push against treating either as a monolith — which is the setup for the periodisation critique next.

6 ★★ Thinking About Time and Historical Periods

The most important section in the chapter for Mains and for general intellectual hygiene.

What historians mean by "time"

Not just hours, days or years on a clock. Time also reflects **changes in social and economic organisation**, and **the persistence and transformation of ideas and beliefs**. Dividing the past into **periods** — large segments with shared characteristics — makes study easier.

✗ The colonial periodisation

In the MIDDLE OF THE 19th CENTURY, British historians divided Indian history into THREE periods:

+-----+	+-----+	+-----+
"HINDU"	--> "MUSLIM"	--> "BRITISH"
+-----+	+-----+	+-----+

THE ASSUMPTION BUILT INTO IT:
that the RELIGION OF RULERS was the ONLY important historical change -- and that there was nothing else worth noticing in the rich diversity of the subcontinent.

⚠️ **Associated above all with James Mill**, whose *History of British India* (1817) set out this scheme. NCERT attributes it to "British historians" of the mid-19th century.

Why historians reject it — say this in an answer

1. It makes **the ruler's religion the master variable**, when economy, society, technology and culture changed independently of it
2. It implies medieval India was defined by religious conflict, **flattening the diversity** the chapter has just documented (recall: two peasants of different religions in one village were *not* foreigners to each other)
3. It treats "Hindu" and "Muslim" as **internally uniform**, when the chapter has shown both were **interpreted in many ways**
4. It laid intellectual groundwork for **communal readings of Indian history** — a live political issue

What historians do instead: *"Most look to **economic and social factors** to characterise the major elements of different moments of the past."*

⚠️ And the honest self-criticism

NCERT then turns the critique on its own book — which is intellectually admirable and very quotable:

The problem with "medieval"

The **16th and 18th centuries** were quite different from the 8th or 11th. Describing the whole span as **one historical unit is not without its problems**

"Medieval" is often contrasted with "modern". **"Modernity" carries a sense of material progress and intellectual advancement** — which implies the medieval period **lacked any change whatsoever**

But that was not the case. Societies were transformed often, and economies in several regions reached a prosperity that **attracted European trading companies**

🎯 **This is a gift for Essay and GS1.** The idea that "*medieval*" is a label that smuggles in a judgement — stagnation, backwardness, a gap between two bright ages — is exactly the kind of critical observation that lifts an answer. **Periodisation is never neutral; it encodes what the person doing the dividing thought mattered.**

⚡ UPSC FOCUS

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
"Hindustan" ★★ ★	Minhaj-i Siraj (13th c.) = political, Punjab/Haryana/Ganga-Yamuna, excluded south India ; Babur (16th c.) = geography, fauna, culture; Amir Khusrau used "Hind"
"Foreigner" ★	Any stranger to a locality; pardesi (Hindi), ajnabi (Persian)
Period covered	700 to 1750
Al-Idrisi ★	Arab geographer, map of 1154 CE , south India at the top, names in Arabic
New technologies ★★	Persian wheel, spinning wheel, firearms
New crops ★★	Potatoes, corn, chillies, tea, coffee
Rajput ★★	From Rajaputra , "son of a ruler"; 8th–14th c.; claimed Kshatriya status; chivalric code
Kayasthas	Caste of scribes and secretaries
Jati / jati panchayat ★★	Sub-caste; ranks varied by region ; assembly of elders enforced its rules
Amir Khusrau, 1318 ★★	Regional languages list; Sanskrit belonged to no region , known only to Brahmanas
Barani ★	14th-c. chronicler who wrote two versions of his chronicle, two years apart
Masalik al-absar...	Egyptian source (Shihabuddin al-Umari) for Muhammad Tughluq's provinces
Islam's arrival ★	Merchants and migrants, 7th century
Shia vs Sunni ★	Ali as legitimate leader vs authority of the Khalifas
Periodisation ★★ ★	"Hindu, Muslim, British" — mid-19th-c. British historians (James Mill); rejected today
Pan-regional empires	Cholas, Khaljis, Tughluqs, Mughals

Traps:

- "Hindustan always meant the whole subcontinent including the south" → **FALSE**. In Minhaj-i Siraj's political usage it **excluded south India**
- "Chillies and potatoes are indigenous Indian crops" → **FALSE**. Introduced in this period
- "Jati ranks were fixed and uniform across India" → **FALSE**. They **varied from area to area**
- "Historians still use the Hindu–Muslim–British periodisation" → **FALSE**. Few do

Mains

- **Historiography / Essay ★★ ★**: "*Periodisation is never a neutral act.*" Use the Hindu–Muslim–British scheme, its assumption, and its consequences

- **Indian Society:** the emergence of **jati**, its regional variability, and social mobility in a period of state formation
- **Culture:** Amir Khusrau on regional languages vs Sanskrit — the vernacular question that runs through Ch.6 and Ch.7
- **Source criticism:** the manuscript-drift problem; Barani's two versions; using it to caveat any claim built on medieval texts

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Cartographer	A person who makes maps
Archive	A place where documents and manuscripts are stored
Manuscript	A handwritten text
Habitat	The environment of a region and the social and economic lifestyle of its residents
Patron	A wealthy individual who supports an artiste, craftsman, learned man or noble
Pardesi / Ajnabi	"Foreigner" (stranger) in Hindi / Persian
Jati	Sub-caste; birth-and-occupation group, ranked, varying by region
Jati panchayat	Assembly of elders enforcing a jati's rules
Rajaputra	"Son of a ruler" — root of "Rajput"
Region	An area with its own geographical, linguistic and cultural characteristics
Pan-regional empire	An empire spanning diverse regions
Periodisation	Dividing the past into periods with shared characteristics
Miniature	A small painting, often used to illustrate manuscripts
Khalifa	Leader of the Muslim community after the Prophet

60-Second Recap

1. **Two maps** (Al-Idrisi 1154, French 1720s) show that sources are shaped by **who made them and why**.
2. **"Hindustan" moved:** political and northern for **Minhaj-i Siraj** (13th c., **excluding the south**), geographical and cultural for **Babur** (16th c.), national for us.
3. **"Foreigner"** meant any stranger to a locality — *pardesi, ajnabi*. **Two peasants of different religions in one village were not foreigners to each other.**
4. **Paper got cheap** between the 13th and 14th centuries, and textual records multiplied.
5. **Scribal copying introduced drift;** we rarely have originals; **Barani** even wrote two versions himself.
6. **New technologies:** Persian wheel, spinning wheel, firearms. **New crops:** potatoes, corn, chillies, tea, coffee.
7. **New groups rose** — **Rajputs** (from *Rajaputra*), Marathas, Sikhs, Jats, Ahoms, and the scribal **Kayasthas**.
8. **Forests were cleared**, forest-dwellers displaced, peasants absorbed into taxpaying society, and **jatis** emerged — **ranked differently in different regions**, governed by **jati panchayats**.
9. **Amir Khusrau (1318)** listed the regional languages and noted **Sanskrit belonged to no region**.
10. **Religion changed:** temple Hinduism and Brahmana dominance grew under royal patronage; **bhakti** emerged; **Islam arrived in the 7th century** with merchants and migrants and was **interpreted in many ways** (Shia/Sunni/Sufi).

11. ★ **The "Hindu–Muslim–British" periodisation** (mid-19th-c. British historians, above all **James Mill**) assumed the ruler's religion was the only thing that mattered. **Historians reject it** and use economic and social criteria instead.
 12. **Even "medieval" is problematic** — it implies a stagnant gap before "modernity", which the evidence contradicts.
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Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. With reference to the term "Hindustan" in the thirteenth century, consider the following:
 1. It was used in a political sense for lands within the Delhi Sultanate.
 2. It included the areas of Punjab, Haryana and the Ganga-Yamuna doab.
 3. It included the whole of south India. → *1 and 2 only. It **never** included south India in that usage.*
2. Which of the following were introduced into the subcontinent during 700–1750?
 1. The Persian wheel 2. Chillies 3. The spinning wheel 4. Potatoes → *All four.*
3. The term "Rajput" derives from — → *Rajaputra, "son of a ruler".*
4. Consider the following statements about jatis:
 1. Their rank was uniform across the subcontinent.
 2. They framed their own rules, enforced by an assembly of elders. → *Only 2. Jati status **varied from area to area.***
5. The division of Indian history into "Hindu", "Muslim" and "British" periods — → *Was made by British historians in the mid-19th century and is rejected by most historians today.*

Mains style

6. *"Periodisation is never a neutral act."* Discuss with reference to the colonial periodisation of Indian history. **(250 words)**
7. Examine the problems historians face in using medieval manuscripts as sources. **(150 words)**
8. *"Medieval Indian identity was organised around locality and community rather than religion."* Comment. **(150 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- How did the meaning of "Hindustan" differ between Minhaj-i Siraj and Babur?
 - Why is the manuscript record unreliable, and what do historians do about it?
 - Name three new technologies and three new crops of this period.
 - What is a jati panchayat, and why did jati rank vary by region?
 - Give three reasons the Hindu–Muslim–British periodisation is rejected.
-